



ULTRALIGHT

Need **145 guns**

A 155 mm howitzer made of light alloys. At 5 tonnes, is less than half the weight of a regular howitzer. Can be rapidly air- or heli-dropped for mountain warfare.

COST: Rs 2,800 crore

STATUS: Trials postponed after ST Kinetics blacklisted.



WHEELED

Need **180 guns**

A 155 mm howitzer mounted on a six-wheeled armoured vehicle. Provides mobile firepower in the plains.

COST: Rs 4,700 crore

STATUS: BAe and Samsung shortlisted. Trials to be announced.

THE WORLD'S BIGGEST GUN BUY

The Indian Army needs 2,700 howitzers worth over Rs 22,000 crore but problems dog purchases

- ➡ The army has not bought a new howitzer since 1987
- ➡ It urgently needs at least 400 new howitzers and 2,000 guns in the next 20 years.
- ➡ At current acquisition rates, it will take five years for the first gun to arrive.
- ➡ Since 1987, the howitzer modernisation plan has been hit by four scandals.
- ➡ Two howitzer manufacturers have been blacklisted and a third is under investigation, further shrinking the list of suppliers.

GUNS

bardment using 155 mm howitzers which can destroy enemy defences and tanks and blast a path through mine-fields is the precursor to an infantry attack and armoured attack. Artillery can be used as a delicate scalpel too—the newest fin-stabilised GPS-guided Precision Guided Munitions (PGMs) can lob a 155 mm artillery shell to within 10 m of a target 50 km away, at one-tenth of the cost of a guided missile. “With better artillery you can punitively react without crossing the threshold,” says Lt-General Vinay Shanker (retired), DG Artillery during the Kargil conflict.

In 1999, the army projected a Field Artillery Modernisation Plan-2017, under which it would replace all the assortment of gun calibres—105 mm, 130 mm and 50 pounders—in its 230

artillery regiments (each regiment has 18 guns) with the standard 155 mm howitzers. The plan called for a variety of howitzers—ranging from howitzers which could be towed by trucks to self-propelled howitzers—wheeled guns in the plains and tracked guns in the deserts. These self-propelled guns could move swiftly providing artillery fire for the strike formations in the plains and deserts. It also proposed the induction of two more types of guns—ultra-light howitzers which could be air-dropped or heli-lifted into the mountains and mounted gun systems—a six-wheeled army truck fitted with a howitzer. Tenders were called from big gun manufacturers: The UK’s BAe Systems for all five gun categories, South Africa’s Denel for the self-propelled howitzers, Israel’s

Soltam for towed, truck-mounted and tracked guns, France’s Nexter, Germany’s Rheinmetall for wheeled howitzers and Korea’s Samsung Techwin for tracked howitzers.

The aim was to complete the modernisation by 2017. But eight years away from the deadline, here is where the programme stands—the army has held five howitzer trials to buy new towed howitzers since 2000 after a tender for 400 guns was floated in 1999 but it has not found the right gun. Initially, the army had shortlisted the FH-77B, the original Bofors gun now owned by BAe Systems. But army officials say that the guns simply failed to meet the army’s stringent trial requirements. Hence, in June this year, the army issued fresh tenders for towed guns, a process that could take between four to five years before the first gun arrives.

Last month, the Defence Acquisition Council cleared a fifth category of howitzers: Mounted Gun Systems. These howitzers, mounted on regular military trucks enable a gun to rapidly ‘shoot and scoot’ without the crew having to leave their vehicle. The army wants 814 of these guns for an estimated Rs 8,500 crore but again, it will be another five years